at times transactional. That naturally raises concerns in New Delhi about whether India's strategic importance could fluctuate depending on the state of US-China ties.

Some strands signal stability. As former Indian ambassador to the United States Meera Shankar put it, "While the White House often appears unpredictable, the broader American establishment, particularly the Pentagon and State Department, continues to strongly support deeper engagement with India. Years of investment in defence cooperation, intelligence-sharing and technology partnerships have created institutional momentum that survives political turbulence. That continuity may prove more important than presidential rhetoric."

On trade, the other major irritant, Rubio optimistically suggested that an agreement could be concluded "within weeks". But the ground reality is far more complicated. The US Supreme Court struck down Trump's reciprocal tariffs as exceeding executive authority, throwing Washington's tariff architecture into uncertainty. For now, a temporary uniform 10 per cent tariff structure applies and Indian policymakers face an obvious question: why voluntarily lock ourselves into an 18 per cent tariff regime negotiated under February's interim agreement when the eventual US tariff framework itself remains unsettled?

On the sensitive issue of immigration, Rubio reiterated that these are global policies rather than India-specific measures. Technically, that may be true. But India inevitably feels the consequences more sharply because Indians have been among the largest beneficiaries of America's legal migration ecosystem. Ironically, despite all the political friction, actual economic integration continues to deepen. Bilateral trade in goods and services crossed $212 billion (Rs 20.3 lakh crore) in 2025. The lesson for India is clear. It must not merely trade more with the US; it must build leverage in select sectors where America needs India as much as India needs America.

EXPERTS SAY INDIA MUST PROCEED WITH EYES WIDE OPEN AND HANDS ON THE WHEEL TO BUILD UPON MARCO RUBIO'S DAMAGE-REPAIR VISIT

A MORE PRACTICAL QUAD

If bilateral ties remain complicated, the Quad grouping (India, Australia, Japan and the US) may ironically have emerged as the steadier framework. Rubio remains one of its strongest advocates, having hosted multiple Quad ministerial meetings. But the Quad itself is evolving. Instead of grand ideological ambitions, it is becoming more practical and focused. That is why the most meaningful outcomes from Rubio's visit came in areas like critical minerals, maritime security, infrastructure and emerging technologies. The new critical minerals initiative that was signed in this round is especially important. China's dominance over global critical mineral supply chains has given Beijing enormous geopolitical leverage. Building alternative supply chains through the Quad countries directly reduces that dependence.

New Delhi's approach, therefore, has become pragmatic: keep negotiations alive, avoid public confrontation, but delay final commitments until there is greater clarity. This reflects India's broader management of Trump-era diplomacy, which Shankar describes as "no confrontation, but no capitulation either". She points out, "Overall, India's handling of the relationship has been notably mature. It remained engaged, avoided excessive rhetoric, but defended core interests." For India, the challenge will be to build upon the damage repair that Rubio's visit achieved and deepen cooperation with the US while insulating itself from the volatility of American domestic politics. As Pankaj Saran, seasoned diplomat and a former deputy national security advisor, puts it, "India will have to proceed with eyes wide open and hands on the wheel." ■

↘ ON THE TRUMP-XI SUMMIT

Here's the bottom line. The US and China are the two largest economies in the world, and we also have powerful militaries. Our countries have to have relations as we want to avoid anything that could lead to destabilisation in any part of the world. So, it was an important visit in the sense that our countries have to be able to speak to one another. But it's also clear that there are specific issues in which we're not going to agree, specific things that we're going to have to address that they probably don't like, such as our over-dependence on them for critical minerals and supply chains.

"I hope we will be able to work with Pakistani authorities to go after these terrorist groups who ultimately pose a threat to the state itself but, in the short term, are a threat to people in the region"

↘ ON DEALING WITH TERROR EMANATING FROM PAKISTAN

We want to deal with terrorism, no matter where it's emanating from. If there are armed groups that are seeking to kill people and conduct acts of terrorism and they're operating within the national space of any country in the world, we need to address it. We've had to address it in our own hemisphere. I would hope that we would be able to work with Pakistani authorities to go after these dangerous groups who ultimately pose a threat to the state itself but, in the short term, pose a threat to people in the region, as well as to the interests of the United States. So, anywhere where terrorism is a threat to our national interests, we want to address it, ideally in cooperation with the country they are located in. ■